

EARLY FLINTLOCK GUNS

Around the 1560s, a new form of gunlock was developed to overcome the inherent problems of the wheel-lock (see p.38). Made out of fewer parts than its predecessor, it used the principle of striking a piece of flint against hardened steel to create sparks to ignite priming powder. The first form of this lock was the snaphance, which had a steel on the end of a pivoting arm. Movement of the cock opened the separate pan cover. A more efficient version, called the flintlock, was developed in the 17th century. This combined the pan cover and steel to form a frizzen, further simplifying the design. Early flintlock weapons came in a variety of shapes and sizes.

► SCOTTISH SNAPHANCE PISTOL WITH LEMON BUTT

Date 1627

Origin Scotland

Barrel 8in (20cm)

Caliber .60in (15.2mm)

This pistol is of classic Highland Scottish form. Snaphance locks were popular in Scotland for much of the 17th century and their stocks, with butts shaped like a lemon, heart, or ram's horns, were usually made of brass or steel.

